THE HOUSE OF IDEAS

An Alternate-History Hollywood Saga

STORY BIBLE — VOLUME 01: FOUNDATIONS

Story Present: Friday, April 28, 2006 — Burbank / Beverly Hills, California

Event: Jon Favreau confirmed as director of *Iron Man*

Working series title — change anytime.

1. The Locked-In Rules

These rules are canon for every future document. Nothing below changes unless you change it.

#	Rule
1	**Story present is 2006.** We move forward from Friday, April 28, 2006. Everything before that date is real history.
2	**Alternate history, one divergence.** The real world is identical (politics, economy, pop culture, other studios, the 2007-08 WGA strike, the 2008 financial crisis). The only thing that differs is *how the MCU is made*, plus the ripple effects that naturally follow.
3	**Format:** character-driven, dialogue-heavy screenplay format, intercut with Hollywood trade articles, news headlines, message boards, blogs, social media and box-office reports — all period-accurate.
4	**Timeline:** every scene carries a date and time. Every real person's age is calculated from their real birthday on the scene date.
5	**The MCU is 100% comic-book accurate** and faithful to the source material.
6	**Absolutely nobody is nerfed.** Every character gets their strongest established comic powers and capabilities.
7	**Off-rights characters still exist in-universe** (see Section 6) so they can slot in with zero retcons once the rights return.
8	**Continuity is extremely important** for both the real-world story and the MCU itself.
9	**Fictional actors** will be created by you later and will exist alongside real actors. No fictional actors are invented until you supply them.
10	**Deliverables are PDFs only.**

2. Where We Are: The Real World, Spring 2006

Context that is true as of the story present. This is the board the game starts on.

Marvel Studios' Position

- **September 2005:** Marvel closes a $525 million, non-recourse credit facility with Merrill Lynch to self-finance its own films. The collateral is the film rights to ten characters: **Ant-Man, The Avengers, Black Panther, Captain America, Cloak & Dagger, Doctor Strange, Hawkeye, Nick Fury, Power Pack and Shang-Chi.** If the films fail, Marvel risks losing those rights.
- **Distribution:** Paramount Pictures will distribute Marvel's self-financed films for a fee. Marvel keeps the upside — and the risk.
- **Iron Man** rights came back from New Line Cinema in 2005. It is the flagship.
- **April 28, 2006:** Jon Favreau is confirmed as director of *Iron Man*, targeting a 2008 release.
- **The Incredible Hulk** is in development at Marvel; Universal retains distribution rights from the 2003 *Hulk* deal.
- **Thor** and **Black Widow** are reverting to Marvel during 2006.

Who Holds What (Spring 2006)

Rights holder	Key Marvel properties
Sony / Columbia	Spider-Man and associated characters (*Spider-Man 3* due May 2007); Ghost Rider (film due 2007)
20th Century Fox	X-Men and mutants (*X-Men: The Last Stand* opens May 26, 2006); Fantastic Four and their world (*Rise of the Silver Surfer* in development); Daredevil and Elektra
Universal	Hulk distribution rights; Namor (tied up in development)
Lionsgate	The Punisher (sequel in development); Man-Thing
New Line	Blade (*Blade: The Series* premieres on Spike TV, summer 2006)
Marvel Studios	Iron Man, Captain America, Thor, Hulk (production), Black Widow, Avengers, Ant-Man, Black Panther, Doctor Strange, Hawkeye, Nick Fury, Shang-Chi, Cloak & Dagger, Power Pack, and most of the cosmic and street-level line

Rights details are condensed for story use. Exact contract terms will be shown in the story as needed, and verified when they matter.

The 2006 Media Landscape (for period accuracy)

- **Trades:** *Variety*, *The Hollywood Reporter*; Nikki Finke's *Deadline Hollywood Daily* blog (launched March 2006). Box Office Mojo for grosses.
- **Fan internet:** Ain't It Cool News (Harry Knowles), Superhero Hype, Newsarama, Comic Book Resources, IGN FilmForce, and countless message boards.
- **Social media:** MySpace dominates. YouTube is a year old. Facebook is college/high-school only until **September 26, 2006**. Twitter does not exist until **July 2006**. The iPhone does not exist until 2007 — executives carry BlackBerrys and flip phones.
- **Comics, right now:** *Civil War* is about to launch (May 2006). *Planet Hulk* has just begun. Ellis and Granov's *Extremis* is wrapping. Brubaker's Winter Soldier is the hottest Captain America story in decades. Bendis's *New Avengers* is a top seller.

Key Real People — Ages on April 28, 2006

Person	Role in 2006	Born	Age
Kevin Feige	President of Production, Marvel Studios	June 2, 1973	32
Avi Arad	Chairman/CEO, Marvel Studios	Aug 1, 1948	57
Jon Favreau	Director, *Iron Man*	Oct 19, 1966	39
Stan Lee	Chairman Emeritus, Marvel	Dec 28, 1922	83
Joe Quesada	Editor-in-Chief, Marvel Comics	Jan 12, 1962	44
Brian Michael Bendis	Writer, *New Avengers*	Aug 18, 1967	38
Mark Millar	Writer, *Civil War* / *The Ultimates*	Dec 24, 1969	36
Robert Downey Jr.	Actor (not yet cast)	Apr 4, 1965	41
Sam Raimi	Director, *Spider-Man 3* (Sony)	Oct 23, 1959	46
Tom Rothman	Co-Chairman, Fox Filmed Entertainment	Nov 21, 1954	51

Ages auto-advance on each birthday. David Maisel, Ike Perlmutter and others will be added with ages once their birth dates are confirmed for the record.

3. Serialized vs. Standalone

A. The Real-World Story: 65% Serialized / 35% Standalone

This is a saga about building something over years, so the big arcs have to carry from chapter to chapter: will Marvel's gamble pay off, will Merrill Lynch take the characters, the Donohue question (will Donohue Entertainment buy Marvel?), the fight to get the rights back, careers rising and falling, rivalries with Fox and Sony, and personal lives under pressure.

Every chapter still needs its own **contained episode-engine** — a casting war, a test screening, a Comic-Con panel, an opening weekend, a leaked script, a rights negotiation — that starts and ends inside the chapter. The 35% keeps every chapter satisfying on its own; the 65% makes the reader need the next one.

Continuity tools: a running Canon Ledger (dates, box office, contracts, who knows what), age tracking for every person, and real-world events (the 2007-08 writers' strike, the 2008 crash, award seasons) as fixed anchor points.

B. The MCU: 60% Serialized / 40% Standalone (slate average)

This is the comics model: every issue is a complete read, but every issue moves the universe forward. The ratio **ramps up by phase** so audiences are brought in before they're asked to keep up:

Stage	Serialized / Standalone	Why
Phase One (2008-2012)	40 / 60	Bring in audiences who don't read comics. Each film is a complete origin with light connective tissue (S.H.I.E.L.D., the Infinity Formula, the Cosmic Cube, Stark tech).
Phase Two	60 / 40	The universe is established. Sequels and new heroes start crossing over; threads from one film pay off in another.
Phase Three and event films	75 / 25	Crossover events (in the spirit of *Kree-Skrull War*, *Avengers Disassembled*, *Civil War*, *Infinity Gauntlet*) where the serialized payoff *is* the movie.
Slate average	**60 / 40**	The sweet spot: you can walk into any film cold, but loyal viewers are rewarded.

The Standalone Guarantee (non-negotiable): every film has a complete A-story — its own hero arc, its own central villain, and a climax resolved within the film — unless it is openly billed as Part One of a two-part event. No required homework. No film exists only to set up another film.

MCU continuity rules: one master Universe Bible and timeline; a continuity officer with veto power over scripts (a great dramatic role for the real-world story); comics events are adapted in order, so payoffs land when they're earned; and nothing is retconned to fix a mistake — mistakes are explained inside the story, the way Marvel's editors historically did it.

4. Genre, Subgenres and Rating — The Real-World Story

Element	Recommendation
Primary genre	**Hollywood industry drama** — a behind-the-scenes saga of how the movies get made.
Subgenres	• Corporate/boardroom drama (financing, rights, takeovers) • Underdog story (a near-bankrupt comics company against the major studios) • Ensemble workplace drama with comedy (writers' rooms, sets, marketing war rooms) • Showbiz satire (agents, trades, fan culture, the early-internet rumor mill) • Docudrama texture (period-accurate headlines, grosses, blog posts) • Character and relationship drama (marriages, burnout, comebacks, rivalries) • Light romance, used sparingly
Tone	Sharp, fast and funny in the rooms; tense in negotiations; emotional on premiere nights. Realistic, never cartoonish.
Rating	**TV-MA (R-equivalent)** — real Hollywood language, adult pressures, addiction and recovery stories handled honestly. Mature, but not gratuitous.

5. Genre, Subgenres, Rating and Runtime — The MCU

Umbrella genre: superhero epic. **The key principle:** each franchise takes its genre from its *defining comics runs*. That variety is what keeps a shared universe from feeling like one movie made over and over.

Franchise	Primary genre / subgenres	Rating
Iron Man	Techno-thriller, military-industrial drama; later an addiction drama (*Demon in a Bottle*)	PG-13
Captain America	WWII war epic, then a paranoid espionage thriller (Steranko and Brubaker)	PG-13
Thor	Mythological epic, cosmic fantasy, Shakespearean family tragedy (Lee/Kirby, Simonson)	PG-13
Hulk	Monster horror, tragedy, fugitive thriller; later gladiator epic and war film (*Planet Hulk*, *World War Hulk*)	PG-13
Doctor Strange	Supernatural horror, psychedelic dark fantasy (Ditko)	PG-13
Black Panther	Political thriller, Afrofuturist epic (Priest, Hudlin)	PG-13
Ant-Man / Wasp	Science adventure, heist caper	PG-13
Shang-Chi	Martial-arts spy thriller (Englehart/Moench)	PG-13
Avengers	Ensemble war epic, disaster film	PG-13
Cosmic (Kree, Skrulls, Thanos, Surfer)	Space opera, cosmic horror (Starlin)	PG-13
Daredevil	Catholic crime noir, legal drama (Miller, Bendis)	R
Punisher	War film, crime revenge thriller (Ennis)	R
Blade, Moon Knight, Werewolf by Night	Horror action, psychological horror	R
Spider-Man	Coming-of-age dramedy, urban adventure	PG-13
X-Men	Civil-rights science-fiction drama, soap opera (Claremont)	PG-13
Fantastic Four	Science-exploration adventure, family drama (Lee/Kirby)	PG-13 / PG

Rating strategy: the core line is a *hard* PG-13 — real stakes, real violence, real consequences. Street-level and horror characters release under a **Marvel Knights** banner rated R, mirroring Marvel's actual Knights and MAX comics imprints. Same universe, same continuity, different doors in.

Runtime Guide

Film type	Target runtime
Solo origin film	125-140 min
Solo sequel	130-150 min
Marvel Knights (R) film	115-135 min
Team-up / Avengers film	150-165 min
Event film / two-part finale	165-185 min per part
Overall slate average	**about 140 min**

6. The No-Nerf Doctrine

Every character receives their **strongest established comic-book powers and capabilities**. Scale is never reduced to make filming easier or to make the story simpler.

Core principle: scale the threat, not the hero. Marvel's comics never solved the Thor-or-Hulk problem by weakening them; they gave them Surtur, the Celestials, the Leader's genius and the Red Hulk. The films do the same. When an audience asks "why didn't they just...?", the story answers in-world: cost, consequence, character, or a counter-power.

Character	Full comics power set (examples, not limits)
Thor	Godly strength on a planetary scale, near invulnerability, Mjolnir (weather and lightning, flight, dimensional travel, the God Blast, the Anti-Force), Asgardian longevity; the Odinforce once he inherits it
Hulk	Strength that rises with his anger with no known upper limit, near-instant regeneration, thunderclaps, mile-spanning leaps, sensing astral forms; the Banner/Hulk personalities as written in the comics
Iron Man	Repulsors, uni-beam, flight, specialized armors (space, stealth, Hulkbuster), satellite links; the Extremis neural interface once he has it; genius-level engineering
Captain America	Peak human Super-Soldier physiology, the vibranium-adamantium alloy shield, one of the greatest tacticians on Earth, unbreakable will
Doctor Strange	Sorcerer Supreme: Eye of Agamotto, Cloak of Levitation, the Vishanti, astral projection, dimensional mastery
Scarlet Witch	Probability manipulation growing into reality warping and chaos magic (*House of M* scale)
Vision	Density control from intangible to diamond-hard, solar-jewel beams, flight, synthezoid intellect
Silver Surfer / Sentry	The Power Cosmic; "the power of a million exploding suns"
Black Widow	Red Room enhancement, slowed aging, Widow's Bite, world-class espionage and combat skills
Off-rights examples	Wolverine (adamantium, healing factor), Phoenix (cosmic), Spider-Man (proportional strength, spider-sense, genius), Galactus (world-eater): all canon at full strength in the Universe Bible

7. The Rights Reservation Doctrine

Characters Marvel doesn't control in 2006 **exist inside the MCU's canon** from day one. The Universe Bible records them — their histories, locations and the events they took part in — so that when the rights come back they slot in with no retcon, no re-origin and no conflicting timeline.

- **On screen, until the rights return:** they are present in ways the contracts allow — world-building gaps left on purpose, events referenced without names, reserved places on the map, and long-running mysteries the audience will later recognize.
- **Off screen:** the legal fights to protect and recover those characters become some of the best drama in the real-world story (Marvel's lawyers against Fox and Sony, studio executives calling each other, deals made on golf courses).
- **When rights return:** the character arrives as if they had always been there — because, in the Bible, they had.

8. Format Sample (style reference — not yet canon)

A short demonstration of how chapters will look. Content here can be replaced when we begin Chapter One.

VARIETY — FRIDAY, APRIL 28, 2006
"Favreau to direct Marvel's 'Iron Man'"
"Elf" helmer takes the controls of Marvel Studios' first self-financed tentpole, eyed for 2008 via Paramount.

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS — KEVIN FEIGE'S OFFICE — BEVERLY HILLS — DAY

SUPER: Friday, April 28, 2006 — 9:14 A.M. PDT

Comic longboxes against every wall. A BlackBerry buzzes on a stack of *Tales of Suspense* reprints. KEVIN FEIGE (32), baseball cap, reads the Variety story on a bulky monitor.

KEVIN FEIGE
(to himself)
It's real now. Can't take it back.

He clicks to the Superhero Hype message board. A thread title: **"FAVREAU?!? The ELF guy??"** — 412 replies.

KEVIN FEIGE (CONT'D)
Four hundred replies before ten in the morning. Good.
They care.

9. Locked In — Ready for Chapter One

- Story present: **Friday, April 28, 2006**.
- Real-world story: **65/35** serialized/standalone; Hollywood industry drama; **TV-MA**.
- MCU: **60/40** slate average (40/60 in Phase One rising to 75/25 for events); genre comes from the defining comics runs; hard **PG-13** core plus R-rated Marvel Knights; about **140 min** average runtime.
- No-Nerf Doctrine and Rights Reservation Doctrine are in force.
- Waiting on you: **your fictional actors**, and your go-ahead to begin Chapter One.